

Chapter 15



The Cuban Missile Crisis, 1962

The Sources of the Crisis: the Cold War Use of Strategic Power

THE SOVIET ATTEMPT to deploy some 42 medium- and some 24 to 32 intermediate-range ballistic missiles secretly in Cuba during the late summer and early fall of 1962 triggered the most dangerous crisis of the Cold War. Never before or since have the Soviet Union and the United States been so close to a shooting war, one that could easily have escalated into a thermonuclear exchange. Unforeseen and unwanted by either side, the tense confrontation was resolved through careful crisis management by both Washington and Moscow and by a hastily arranged *quid pro quo* in which Khrushchev agreed to remove his missiles from Cuba in return for a pledge by Kennedy not to invade Cuba in the future.

The Soviet deployment of missiles into Cuba represented a major failure of United States deterrence policy, albeit one of an unconventional variety. The Soviet action was not one of the classical military actions that deterrence strategy is normally designed to discourage. Nor, despite its clandestine character, was the missile deployment intended to set the stage for a Soviet resort to military force. While the Soviets certainly wished to achieve surprise with their deployment, it was not part of a plan for a surprise attack upon the United States or any of its

allies. Rather, the deployment was the grandest—and, as it turned out, the last—in a series of increasingly ambitious efforts the two superpowers had been making to exploit their strategic armories for politico-diplomatic purposes. President Kennedy's decision to demand the removal of the missiles, even at a significant risk of major war, was motivated not by fear that the Soviets would make some direct military use of them, but by his expectation that the Kremlin would transmute the improved strategic posture that Cuban-based missiles would give them into a variety of important Cold War gains.

Before examining the Cuban missile crisis itself, therefore, we should look with a little care into its roots in the Cold War. Until the latter part of the 1950s, the traditional pattern of U.S. Cold War policy had been to invoke America's strategic superiority over the Soviet Union not only to deter the Soviets from initiating general or limited war but also to impose constraints on their pursuit of foreign policy goals which the United States regarded as threatening or illegitimately expansionist. The doctrine of Massive Retaliation, of course, represented the apotheosis of this effort. It does not require much imagination to understand the frustration that Kremlin leaders must have felt at this strategy, and their eagerness to neutralize it and even, if possible, to turn it against its makers. As their own capabilities grew, the Soviet captains proved apt pupils of the American lesson on translating strategic power into a foreign policy tool. Even before the Soviets put Sputnik into orbit in the autumn of 1957, they had begun to employ strategic threats (as in the Suez crisis) for politico-diplomatic purposes. However, the shorter-range Soviet missiles, targeted on Western Europe, did not permit credible threats of this kind against the United States itself. So long as this situation obtained, the credibility of the American threat to retaliate directly against the Soviet Union protected weaker allies who were themselves at a disadvantage vis-à-vis Soviet military power.

This situation changed abruptly and in a most spectacular fashion when the Soviets demonstrated a technological breakthrough of far-reaching implications by successfully test-

ing an intercontinental ballistic missile (ICBM) in late August 1957. The message that the United States was no longer invulnerable, and more, was in danger of being surpassed in military technology was driven home and absorbed deeply into the national consciousness when six weeks later the Soviets orbited the first earth satellite. The psychological impact on the United States was far greater than it had been when the Soviets had tested their first A-bomb and, later, demonstrated a capability for developing an H-bomb. The fact that Sputnik orbited directly and repeatedly over the United States did much to symbolize the nation's vulnerability to the Soviet ICBM. Public alarm mounted when in November Sputnik II demonstrated that Soviet missiles could put a very large payload into space and when, in due course, U.S. intelligence estimated that the Soviet ICBM production capability might be much larger than had been expected.

American uncertainty and anxiety regarding the development of Soviet strategic capabilities provided Khrushchev with a tempting opportunity to neutralize the Cold War advantages the United States had been realizing from its strategic superiority. He proceeded to use the ICBM threat to invigorate his own foreign policy. Increasingly, Khrushchev played upon American and Western fears that the Soviets were creating a "missile gap" in their favor. From 1957 to 1962 the Soviet government engaged in a deliberate, systematic, and sustained campaign of deception. It issued grossly exaggerated claims regarding the production and deployment of ICBMs and highly inflated statements of the strength and numbers of the Soviet ICBM force vis-à-vis that of the United States. After Khrushchev initiated the Berlin "deadline crisis" in late 1958 (chapter 13, *infra*), the effort to deceive the West with regard to Soviet ICBM capabilities became more contrived and systematic. Until the Cuban missile crisis, it occupied a central place in Soviet policy.¹

While Moscow made a pretense of employing strategic threats for deterrence purposes in several diplomatic crises

¹ Horelick and Rush, *Strategic Power*, pp. 117–19.

(Syria, 1957; Iraq, 1958; Quemoy, 1958; Cuba, 1961) and for “compellant” (coercive) purposes in other cases (Suez, 1956; American U-2 flights over Russia, 1960), the most serious use it made of strategic threats in this period was in support of Soviet Cold War diplomacy in the Berlin crisis of 1958–1959, which resumed again in 1961. As Horelick and Rush observe,² the Soviet Union did not attempt to secure changes in the status quo of Berlin directly, by the use of strategic threats. Rather, strategic threats were employed (1) to increase the effect of the nonstrategic instruments of pressure that the Soviet Union brought to bear, and (2) to limit the West’s freedom of action in opposing them.

Khrushchev attempted to use his strategic claims to erode the Western will to resist his demands and to deter undesirable responses the United States and its Western allies might make to the diplomatic pressure he brought to bear. As it turned out, however, he overestimated the West’s willingness to make the concessions he demanded. He failed to undermine sufficiently Washington’s confidence in its deterrence posture, although he came closer to doing so against Kennedy in the earlier phase of the 1961 crisis than against Eisenhower in the 1958–1959 crisis over Berlin. But it was President Kennedy who thoroughly discredited Khrushchev’s strategic claims in September and October of 1961 by disclosing new intelligence that conclusively laid to rest the “missile gap” fear.

Indeed, the attempted use of strategic power for Cold War purposes during these years was interacting with the arms race in ways that were imperfectly understood by the leaders on both sides. Khrushchev did not in fact engage in a race with the United States to deploy ICBMs, but he spoke as if he were catching up to and surpassing the United States in strategic power. In addition to hoping that his strategic deception would facilitate his Cold War diplomacy, Khrushchev may have acted as he did between 1957 and 1962, to convince hard-liners in the Soviet Union that Moscow could realize the diplomatic fruits of

² *Ibid.*, pp. 11–13.

strategic power without having to make the expensive outlays needed to acquire it. Or perhaps Khrushchev was also buying time, trying to conceal from the United States that Moscow had decided not to deploy large numbers of inferior first-generation ICBMs while it proceeded to develop more sophisticated missiles for deployment later on.

But whatever the explanation for Khrushchev's behavior, his bombastic strategic claims created the illusion that the Soviet Union was engaged in a serious and successful strategic arms race with the United States. This could only stimulate American anxieties and increase the pressure for greater arms expenditures. The full impact was felt not in the defense policies of President Eisenhower, although he did reluctantly expedite certain programs as a hedge against a major missile gap in the future, but rather on the attitudes and defense policies of the Kennedy Administration when it came into office in January 1961. The intelligence capabilities available to Eisenhower were sufficient to give him confidence that the Soviet ICBM force remained quite small in numbers, Khrushchev's rhetorical exaggerations notwithstanding. Eisenhower saw the "missile gap" as arising, if at all, in the future and not reaching a peak until 1963, at which time the solid-fueled Polaris and Minuteman missiles were due to become operational in large numbers. Having in the meantime decided to forego any large U.S. deployment of the relatively unsatisfactory liquid-propellant, first-generation missiles, Eisenhower refused to be panicked into acquiring a substantially larger number of these inferior ICBMs by the threat of a missile gap. Such a gap could emerge, according to Eisenhower's intelligence specialists, only if the Soviets decided to procure and deploy large numbers of their own liquid-fueled, first-generation missiles. Eisenhower was willing to accept a missile gap if the Soviets moved in this direction, believing that a missile gap—if not too pronounced—would *not* be the equivalent of a "deterrence gap." In other words, Eisenhower counted on the overall level of strategic force available to the United States, including its large strategic bomber force, to maintain an adequate deterrent capability during the

period in which the Soviets might possess a larger number of operational ICBMs than the United States.

However, Eisenhower did not succeed very well in allaying the growing concern of his defense critics that a dangerous “missile gap” was in fact emerging. Their long-standing dissatisfaction with his reliance on Massive Retaliation was compounded by a gnawing feeling that the conservative economic philosophy of his administration, manifested in a stubborn reluctance to increase the defense budget, was driving it into an attitude of complacency and myopia with regard to the growing Soviet strategic threat. These defense critics feared that the Soviets might well acquire enough ICBMs for a successful disarming attack on SAC bases.³ In other words, they believed that the missile gap might indeed result in a “deterrence gap.” They also feared that, in any case, the Soviets might succeed in making major Cold War gains from their growing superiority in missiles.

Intelligence on the actual Soviet missile force was, of course, a critical factor in this controversy over the adequacy of the current and projected U.S. strategic posture. Considerable confusion was created by the way in which U.S. intelligence chose to estimate the future as against the current number of Soviet ICBMs. For several years, U.S. intelligence attempted to deal with this question on the basis of Soviet production capabilities, rather than Soviet intentions. The U.S. estimate thus referred to the maximum number of ICBMs the Soviet Union could have, year by year, in the near future if it produced them at full capacity. This was, in other words, a “worst case” analysis that compared the maximum number of ICBMs the Soviets were *capable* of producing with the number of ICBMs the United States *intended* to produce within a given time period. Such a comparison was justified, of course, on the ground that there was no way of reading Soviet intentions and that the

³ According to some calculations, as few as 175 Soviet ICBMs could take out all the vulnerable strategic air bases in the United States while Soviet MRBMs from Russia eliminated the overseas SAC bases. Quester, *Nuclear Diplomacy*, p. 151.

United States had to take into account the maximum possible future threat.⁴

In January 1960 Eisenhower's Secretary of Defense, Thomas Gates, introduced a new method of estimating the future Soviet ICBM force in terms of what it was expected the Soviets *would* choose to build and deploy. The new focus on Soviet intentions rather than on production capability considerably reduced the expected missile gap, but it also led, predictably, to a new criticism: that the administration was gambling with U.S. security by attempting to read the Soviet mind rather than basing U.S. requirements on Soviet capabilities. The administration was accused of doctoring the basis for its estimate of future Soviet ICBMs for domestic political purposes.

Controversy and confusion over the missile gap and the related question of the administration's own ICBM plans was compounded by secrecy. Unknown to most critics of Eisenhower's relatively sanguine attitude was a special intelligence source for his estimates of the Soviet missile force. The fact that the United States had been conducting U-2 photographic reconnaissance flights over the Soviet Union since 1956 was a well-kept secret until May 1960, when Khrushchev disclosed that the Soviets had finally succeeded in shooting down one of these planes and capturing its pilot, Francis Gary Powers. General knowledge from this time on that Eisenhower's intelligence estimates had been drawing upon the results of the U-2 flights did not, however, alleviate concern over the possible emergence of a missile gap in the near future. There were several reasons for this. First, of course, there was the fact that U-2 intelligence showing a limited Soviet ICBM deployment thus far did not exclude large-scale production and deployment in the future. Moreover, while acknowledging that U-2 flights had been taking place, the administration withheld specific information

⁴ In January 1959 Secretary of Defense Neil McElroy provided a reduced estimate of Soviet production capabilities in an off-the-record statement. But even this suggested that if the Soviet Union worked at maximum capacity, it could have three times as many ICBMs by 1962 as the United States. Others estimated that the disparity would be even greater.

regarding the extent to which U-2 flights had covered the Soviet Union and the thoroughness of the information gained by this and other intelligence methods. Even within the administration itself, as repeated leaks indicated, the experts apparently disagreed in their interpretations of the available data, some of them—most notably the air force specialists—taking a less sanguine view than Eisenhower of the growing Soviet strategic threat. It was not immediately apparent to what extent the more pessimistic, alarmist estimates of Soviet capabilities within the administration were based on a legitimate interpretation of the uncertain evidence, and to what extent they went beyond this for parochial reasons, in order to develop a stronger case for expansion of American forces. Nor was the malaise of the outside critics relieved by one or two instances in which administration officials appeared to be manipulating the estimate of Soviet capabilities in order to counter public fears of a missile gap; and, indeed, went so far as to push the view that the adequacy of the American deterrent could not be judged mainly on the basis of the relative number of ICBMs possessed by the two sides. However accurate the administration's U-2-based estimates may have been, in any case Eisenhower called off further flights of this kind after Powers' U-2 was shot down in May 1960. Whether or not this cessation would create a serious gap in U.S. intelligence coverage of the Soviet missile force (the Eisenhower Administration was reluctant to clarify this question by revealing its plans for the use of intelligence-gathering satellites) it *would* serve to keep alive, if not indeed augment, anxiety over the possibility of a sudden missile gap in the near future, should the Soviet Union embark on a crash ICBM program.

Certainly this fear was nourished by Khrushchev's dramatic and chilling boasts regarding the rapid and substantial growth of the Soviet missile force, as well as his continuing efforts to make politico-diplomatic use of these threats. Later, it was to come as a distinct surprise to many of those most concerned about the missile gap that so large an element of deception entered into Khrushchev's boasts about Soviet intercontinental

missiles. The fact of the matter was that the Soviet Union was deploying very few ICBMs and would not deploy many for a number of years.⁵

We have examined the history of the missile gap problem in some detail because it set the stage for the new strategic policies of President Kennedy—which, in turn, generated much of the pressure on Khrushchev to deploy strategic missiles in Cuba. Kennedy came into the Presidency genuinely convinced that Eisenhower had allowed grave deficiencies to develop in the U.S. military posture and determined to do something about it. During his campaign, Kennedy had taken the danger of the “missile gap” quite seriously and had promised increased expenditures on strategic and other forces. Sorensen reports that the U-2 evidence was not made available to Kennedy during the presidential campaign in the classified briefings he was given by the Eisenhower Administration.⁶ However, the intelligence estimates handed over to the new administration, indicated that fear of a missile gap had been highly exaggerated, though some uncertainty existed for the future. The first SAMOS reconnaissance satellite was launched in January 1961, and it would be a while before the uncertainty affecting intelligence on the growth of the Soviet ICBM force, arising from the cancellation of U-2 flights, would be clarified by this new means of gathering intelligence.

Kennedy decided to proceed with plans for a substantial augmentation of American strategic forces. The Polaris program

⁵ Sorensen suggests that the first Soviet ICBM had apparently been “too costly, too cumbersome and too vulnerable a weapon for mass production and deployment.” The Soviet government then settled for deployment of a very few of these missiles “while pushing ahead on the deployment of medium-range missiles aimed at Europe and the development of a better ICBM.” Sorensen, *Kennedy*, pp. 611–12. Hilsman indicates that American intelligence came to the conclusion that the giant rocket of 800,000 lbs. thrust which the Soviets developed initially (as compared to the 350,000 lbs. thrust of the American Atlas missile) proved “too bulky to serve as a practical weapon. A newer, smaller, more streamlined missile had to be designed instead, and the Soviet ICBM program must have been set back many months.” Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 162.

⁶ Sorensen, *Kennedy*, p. 612.

was accelerated by nine or ten months, ten additional Polaris submarines were added to the programmed force, the production capacity for Minuteman missiles was doubled, and the alert posture of the B-52 force improved. Kennedy undertook these measures to strengthen his strategic forces, not merely to redeem campaign promises, and not to cover embarrassment at learning that the missile gap about which he and his supporters had expressed alarm did not really exist. He still faced genuine and major uncertainties regarding Soviet development of strategic forces.⁷ Kennedy also knew he would soon have to face another crisis over Berlin. Besides, he had four and possibly eight years in office to look forward to. It required no special imagination or paranoid anxiety to envisage how difficult it would be to cope with Khrushchev's already vigorous foreign policy as the Soviet Union acquired even more extensive strategic capabilities in the near future. Having seen how boldly Khrushchev utilized the limited strategic forces then available to him, Kennedy might well feel it to be prudent to push ahead with measures to retain a decisive margin of strategic superiority, in order to cope better with Khrushchev's Cold War tactics in the future. While Kennedy entered office hoping to bring about a modification of the Cold War during his presidency, he thought that a stronger and more flexible American military posture would be required at least until the Soviets gave up their claims on West Berlin and moderated the offensive thrust of their foreign policy.

Later in 1961, Khrushchev continued pressure on West Berlin even after erecting the Wall to seal off the flow of refugees from East Berlin. At this point Kennedy apparently decided to disclose the new intelligence at his disposal—evidently derived from the SAMOS program—to bring the weight of the actual,

⁷ Hilsman states that "when the Kennedy Administration took office, the evidence on the Soviet missile deployment was still inconclusive. . . . even as late as June 1961 the evidence was contradictory and the intelligence community continued to be divided. . . . It was not until the summer and fall of 1961 that the Americans discovered the true situation—and decided to tell the Soviets that they knew." *To Move A Nation*, p. 163.

considerable American strategic superiority to bear in order to defuse the Berlin crisis. Kennedy had long been concerned that Khrushchev would miscalculate over Berlin; he authorized the disclosure of the new intelligence estimate, despite some misgivings, because he feared that otherwise Khrushchev might push the crisis dangerously close to war.⁸ At first, leaks to the press in September indicated that the new U.S. intelligence estimates now credited the Soviet Union with but a fraction of the operational ICBMs that it had been expected to have by mid-1961. Then in October, Deputy Defense Secretary Roswell Gilpatric issued an authoritative and confident appraisal of the strategic balance. He unequivocally asserted that the U.S. had a wide and growing margin of strategic superiority over the Soviet Union. Gilpatric's speech and subsequent statements by other high officials reflected a top-level decision by Kennedy to correct the erroneous impression of a missile gap and, thereby, to deprive the Soviets of any further politico-diplomatic leverage derived from their exaggerated claims.

Confronted by this high-level American deflation of its strategic deception, the Soviet Union responded promptly with angry accusations; but most revealingly, it avoided contradicting the substance of Gilpatric's assessment of the strategic situation. In the months that followed, the Soviets modified their earlier claims of superiority, employing rhetorical devices which tacitly acknowledged the correctness of the new American appraisal.⁹

With his strategic deception of the last four years now unmasked, Khrushchev was left in a difficult position. He had no choice but to abandon the vigorous thrust of his foreign policy until he developed a real strategic capability. The costs of failure in strategic deception were not confined to frustration over the Berlin situation and the larger set of European security issues in which it was imbedded. There is reason to believe

⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 163.

⁹ Horelick and Rush, *Strategic Power*, pp. 83–102. See also Kahan and Long, "The Cuban Missile Crisis," pp. 565–66.

that Khrushchev's strategic claims had misled his Chinese Communist allies regarding Soviet power and encouraged them to press Moscow for new commitments to Peking's foreign policy goals which Soviet leaders were reluctant to assume. In addition to contributing indirectly to Sino-Soviet discord, Khrushchev's strategic deception had stimulated pressure for increased arms in the United States. As a result, the strategic situation facing the Soviet Union was now considerably worse than it would have been otherwise, and it was likely to remain so for some years unless a way could be found to achieve a rapid augmentation of the Soviet strategic capability.

In sum, events had come full circle since the mid-1950s, when Massive Retaliation had been in bloom. Once again, the Kremlin leaders were confronted by an opponent across the ocean who possessed strategic superiority, who knew it, and who was prepared to employ it (although no longer under the same name) for invidious politico-military ends—bolstering the deterrence of highly desired Soviet initiatives. (Indeed the situation was gloomier and more dangerous in 1962 than it had been seven years earlier, for now the Soviet leaders were confronted with a rising threat on their southeastern border.) Unless a way could be found—and quickly—to neutralize the growing American strategic superiority, the future would probably hold few successes for Soviet policy against the imperialists, which would also exacerbate problems with the Chinese.

In this way the ground was prepared for Khrushchev's 1962 gamble. The missile deployment in Cuba was the most dramatic strategic move in the competition, which both superpowers pursued, to extract maximum politico-diplomatic mileage from expensive and otherwise unusable thermonuclear weapons systems. More broadly, the Cuban missile crisis exemplified the ill-understood and "hidden," but increasing, risks of this competition. The gravest threat of thermonuclear war the world has thus far experienced resulted from the increasingly heavy reliance both sides were putting on their deterrent postures and forces in order to achieve too broad a range of foreign policy objectives. Fortunately the crisis itself made these risks

visible and led the superpowers to pull back from this kind of competition. The Soviet leaders accepted the fact that they would have to neutralize the U.S. strategic position the hard way by shifting resources from other desired objectives to build up their advanced strategic forces. As this policy came to fruition in the late 1960s, the United States, for its part, accepted a position of parity or “sufficiency” in thermonuclear forces. Thus, the stage was set for SALT and related efforts to bring the arms race under control. Both superpowers, frightened by the Cuban missile crisis and distracted by the demands of an increasingly multipolar international system, tacitly agreed to stop trying to translate their strategic deterrent forces into politico-diplomatic advantage, at least vis-à-vis each other.

The Initiator's Motivation and Calculus

With this background in hand on the sources of the crisis, we may turn now to the deterrence dynamics of the crisis itself, beginning with a closer analysis of the motivations and calculations of the initiating power than we have made so far.

We may safely surmise that, having seen their campaign of strategic deception come to a bad end, Khrushchev and his closest supporters within the Soviet leadership group were under considerable psychological and political pressure to recoup the situation as quickly as possible. Knowledge that the real missile gap favored the United States rather than the Soviet Union restored Western self-confidence and altered the world political climate. By the end of 1961, it was evident that Soviet foreign policy had lost its forward momentum and was encountering disappointments on many fronts. And, as Horelick and Rush observe, “The Chinese Communist attack on Khrushchev centered precisely on the unfavorable trend in the cold war, which the Chinese attributed to Khrushchev’s faulty and erratic leadership.”¹⁰

¹⁰ Horelick and Rush, *Strategic Power*, p. 139.

It is not known definitely how the idea of deploying strategic missiles in Cuba originated, whether with Castro or with the Russians themselves. (After the end of the crisis Castro issued contradictory accounts on this question.)¹¹ In any case, once the possibility of deploying some of their older, more plentiful medium and intermediate range missiles in Cuba was suggested, it must have recommended itself to Soviet leaders, as Hilsman notes, as “at least a temporary and expedient solution to their several problems. . . . It would give them a cheap and immediate substitute for the newer, more expensive ICBM’s and let them stretch out the ICBM program to ease pressure on resources.”¹²

No one can be certain as to exactly what specific and general benefits the Soviet leaders hoped to derive directly and indirectly from a successful deployment of their missiles in Cuba. One specialist on the USSR, Adam Ulam, suggests that a whole host of benefits may have been expected by Khrushchev and that, indeed, the missile deployment was the linchpin of an ambitious grand strategy which he concocted to deal with his major global and domestic problems.¹³ Other writers attribute somewhat less ambitious goals to Khrushchev’s missile gambit, though agreeing that the Soviet government was pursuing multiple Cold War benefits and not merely deterrence of an American invasion of Cuba. Hilsman reports that one group of Sovietologists in the State Department concluded that the decision to move missiles into Cuba was best viewed as “a generalized, strategic response to a whole set of problems, military, economic, and political” facing Soviet leaders in 1962. “A general improvement in the Soviet military position would affect the entire political context, strengthening their hand for dealing with the whole range of problems facing them. . . .”¹⁴ Graham Allison’s study raises useful cautions against the tendency of

¹¹ *Ibid.*, 134–36. In *Khrushchev Remembers* (p. 493) the former Soviet premier states that the Cuban missile deployment was his own idea.

¹² Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 164.

¹³ Ulam, *Expansion and Coexistence*, pp. 668–69.

¹⁴ Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, pp. 161, 164.

these analysts to deduce Soviet objectives from American perceptions of what Americans in the Kremlin might see as benefits; at the same time, however, he too believes that a variety of goals motivated the Soviet deployment.¹⁵

In any case, whatever the full scope of Soviet objectives, the Soviet decision to proceed with deployment of strategic missiles was evidently made during the spring or early summer of 1962. It was part of a general Soviet arms buildup in Cuba that followed an easing of tensions in Soviet-Cuban relations. The first Soviet arms shipments began to arrive in late July and were cloaked in secrecy. No public announcement of the Soviet agreement to supply arms was made until Che Guevara's visit to Moscow of late August resulted in a joint communiqué on September 2. This communiqué stated that the Soviet Union had agreed to help Cuba meet threats from "aggressive quarters" by delivering "armaments and sending technical specialists for training Cuban servicemen."¹⁶

In retrospect it seems clear, however, that this communiqué was part of the Kremlin's tapestry of deception blanketing its true activities and motives in Cuba. The 42 MRBMs and 24 to 32 IRBMs being sent then to the island increased by half again the total destructive power which the Soviets could inflict upon the United States. Only a fraction of the "lower 48" states were out of range of the IRBMs, the number of which might, of course, have been increased later had Washington tolerated their presence. For these and other reasons we find it difficult to avoid the conclusion of Horelick and Rush that the Kremlin

¹⁵ Allison prefers the explanation that various elements of the Soviet leadership group agreed upon the missile deployment for different reasons. This accords with a familiar observation about policy-making in complex organizations, namely, that various members often agree on a policy means without sharing the same notion of policy ends. But Allison applies this hypothesis to Soviet policy-making somewhat too rigidly, rejecting altogether the notion of "grand global planning" behind the Soviet decision to deploy the missiles. He slips into a false antithesis in assuming that overall planning is necessarily inconsistent with "a process in which a number of different individuals' quite distinct perceptions of separable problems snowballed into a single solution." Allison, *Essence of Decision*, p. 237.

¹⁶ Pachter, *Collision Course*, p. 175.

was making “a bold effort to alter the unfavorable strategic environment in which the USSR found itself in 1962 as the result of the United States intercontinental buildup and the collapse of the ‘missile gap’ myth.”¹⁷ Although the missile deployment,

¹⁷ Horelick and Rush, *Strategic Power*, p. 127. The thesis that the Soviet missile deployment was intended solely or primarily to deter a U.S. attack on Cuba, as claimed by Moscow, is examined and rebutted by Horelick, “The Cuban Missile Crisis”; Horelick and Rush, *Strategic Power*, pp. 127–36; Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, pp. 161–65 and 201–202; and Ulam, *Expansion and Coexistence*, pp. 668–77.

Secret deployment of nuclear missiles, especially the IRBMs, to Cuba would have been an extremely unconventional way of providing deterrence protection to Castro, to say the least. Other options would have been much less risky. Moscow might have made vigorous deterrent statements, delivered a formal treaty guarantee, provided substantial military aid to strengthen Castro’s own conventional forces, or deployed Soviet combat forces to Cuba to play a “plate glass” role like U.S. forces in Berlin. Moscow could have threatened to retaliate elsewhere, e.g. Berlin, should the U.S. attack Cuba, or brought Cuba into the Warsaw Pact.

Instead, Moscow took the unprecedented step of deploying major strategic weapons systems—never placed on the territory of its East European satellites despite the huge Soviet ground forces there—outside its formal alliance system. Moreover, unlike the United States, which had openly carried out the deployment of strategic missiles in allied territory, the Soviets moved secretly, under cover of high-level, systematic deception. At first, Moscow left dark the question whether Moscow or Havana would have operational control over these missiles. Finally, the presence of IRBMs as well as MRBMs in the deployed forces makes it extremely improbable that Moscow’s motive was simply the protection of Castro. The MRBMs—cheaper, more mobile, and easier to handle—would have been ample to deter an attack on Cuba, as they could reach many American cities in the South. The IRBMs, however, extended the Soviet “reach” to most of the United States—useful for the general purposes of the Soviet Union but redundant so far as protecting Castro was concerned.

Allison is the sole major interpreter of the crisis who challenges this thesis; see *Essence of Decision*, pp. 113, 247. Allison’s alternative explanation, that the IRBMs may have been included in the deployment as a result of the play of the routines or organizational goals of institutions within the Soviet government, has a serious weakness: it requires us to believe that the top-level Soviet leaders were either unaware of or indifferent to the implications of having suborganizations take the risk-enhancing step of adding IRBMs to the force.

In his reminiscences, the full authenticity of which remains uncertain, Khrushchev claimed the primary reason for putting missiles into Cuba was to deter a U.S. attack. However, the former Soviet Premier went on to say “In addition to protecting Cuba, our missiles would have equalized what the West likes to call ‘the balance of power’.” *Khrushchev Remembers*, pp. 493–94.

in the quantity existing when it was discovered, did not shift the military strategic balance in favor of the Soviet Union, it began to approach equalizing that balance. It would have placed Khrushchev once more in a position to make use of strategic threats in support of a broad range of foreign policy goals, this time with even greater credibility than when he attempted to exploit American uncertainty over Soviet ICBMs. As President Kennedy said later, the danger of the missile deployment lay not in the immediate military threat of the Cuban-based missiles; rather, as he put it, the missile deployment “would have politically changed the balance of power. It would have appeared to, and appearances contribute to reality.”¹⁸

Clearly, an objective of this magnitude would have been sufficient motivation for the Soviets to accept moderate risks in its pursuit. There are good reasons for believing, however, that the Kremlin assessed its risks in this venture as reasonable and controllable ones. In the first place, the built-in capability of the MRBMs, especially, for very rapid deployment probably encouraged the Soviet leaders to think that these missiles could be made operational in Cuba before they were discovered by the Americans. Moreover, Moscow is presumed to have known that U.S. intelligence was not aware of this rapid-deployment feature of the MRBMs, and therefore to have hoped for a successful surprise deployment. (It is certainly true that U.S. intelligence had underestimated the rapid-deployment capability of the Soviet MRBM.) Once a few MRBMs were operational in Cuba, of course, they would serve to deter U.S. attacks while additional missiles, including the IRBMs, were being readied. Soviet leaders therefore had reasonable grounds for thinking they might achieve a *fait accompli* which, by its very nature, would be difficult for the United States to undo.

It is true, of course, that early in September President Kennedy committed himself to opposing any deployment of offensive missiles in Cuba. The Soviet deployment decision, however, was apparently made prior to the President's statement.

¹⁸ Interview with President Kennedy, *Washington Post*, December 18, 1962.

While Kennedy's declaration might have had an effect had it come while the deployment was still being debated in the Kremlin, it was evidently inadequate to reverse the policy once it had been launched. Soviet leaders evidently thought that whatever the statements from Washington, once the missiles were deployed it would be difficult for the Americans to find practical options for securing their removal.

Furthermore, the Soviet leaders probably expected that the American political system would respond sluggishly to discovery of the missiles, and that the Kennedy Administration would be incapable of formulating a decisive course of action in the face of Soviet threats and political pressures. Such an expectation was certainly reasonable, and it would further encourage the Soviet belief that the critical MRBM portion of the missile deployment might be completed even if discovered by the United States in process. The elaborate cloak of deception the Soviets threw over the entire operation—consistently maintained up to and including direct falsehoods from the Soviet Ambassador to the President—was designed, of course, not only to delay the date of discovery of the missiles but also to delay a coherent American response thereafter. Indeed, if Kennedy's warning was meant to imply that he would take action to remove missiles in Cuba *immediately* upon discovering them, events justified the Soviets' scepticism.¹⁹

In calculating the risks of deploying the missiles, therefore, the Soviet leaders believed, first, that there was an excellent chance of a *fait accompli*; and second, that if by chance they were discovered in the process, that the initial U.S. response would probably be a hesitant one, and would almost certainly be diplomatic and political rather than military in character. The graver risk—to the Kremlin an unacceptable one—of a major

¹⁹ Thus, there are indications that the Pentagon had prepared contingency plans for an invasion or air strike in the event offensive missiles were discovered; but when that event transpired these contingency plans were set aside. For, as Paul Nitze recalled, at that point top U.S. policy-makers "agreed that the U.S. must move with deliberation, not merely proceed with existing contingency plans." Abel, *The Missile Crisis*, p. 21.

shooting war with the United States would develop, if at all, only at a later point in the crisis, after intervening events had transpired which the Kremlin could probably manipulate to control its overall risks. Once again, therefore, we see the Soviet decision-makers willing to accept high risks in the later stages of a possible crisis scenario, *so long as* the initial risks were assessed as low, and the potentially dangerous later stages were sufficiently removed in time and by intervening events to allow crisis-control measures to be taken. As Roger Hilsman puts it,

This is not to say that the Soviets thought the Cuba venture was without risk. But it does indicate that they thought of it as an easily manageable risk. As it turned out, the risk was manageable; the error was thinking that it would be easy.²⁰

The error came partly from the Soviets' underestimation of the President. It is often remarked that Khrushchev viewed Kennedy as weak, inexperienced, and irresolute—a judgment seemingly derived from, or fortified by, the President's comparative youth, his handling of the Bay of Pigs fiasco, and his performance in Vienna in June 1961. Nearly everyone who has examined the Cuban missile crisis agrees that the Soviets were operating on an incorrect image of their opponent and were genuinely surprised when Kennedy reacted as firmly as he did. Clearly, this misestimate of their opponent could only strengthen their belief that the missile deployment would not entail excessive risk.²¹

²⁰ Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 182. In all probability, the Kremlin estimated that the very worst outcome it could plausibly conceive would be a U.S. air strike on the missile sites while still under construction. The *loss* to the USSR in this contingency would be serious, but the *risk* of uncontrollable escalation spiralling out of this event would be low, due to Cuba's isolated location, far from any other communist territory or interest. Note, furthermore, that events justified the Soviet estimate that this was an *improbable* U.S. action even if the missiles were discovered prematurely.

²¹ It is interesting that Kennedy was aware of the Soviets' misperception of him and anxious to correct it (Schlesinger, *A Thousand Days*, p. 319). When he learned that Khrushchev had been secretly putting missiles into Cuba while systematically deceiving him with false assurances, he realized that Khrushchev

Further, their misperception of the President must have been reinforced by an apparently erroneous interpretation of his responses to the warnings he was beginning to receive by September 1962.

The Defender's Response to Warning: The Policy Response

In late August and September of 1962 President Kennedy obtained what might be considered strategic warning that the steadily increasing Soviet military assistance to Cuba might develop along more ambitious, more dangerous lines. A U-2 flight over Cuba on August 29 obtained photographic verification of earlier indications that the Russians were bringing in surface-to-air missiles (SAMs) of the kind that had shot down the U-2 plane piloted by Gary Powers. Although most members of the administration thought it quite unlikely that the Soviets would go so far as to introduce strategic missiles into Cuba or attempt to convert it into a Soviet military base, they recognized that either eventuality would pose a grave challenge to American interests. A more immediate and urgent consideration in the administration's thinking at this time, however, was the fact that mounting Soviet military assistance to Castro was seriously increasing political challenges within the United States. Criticism of the administration mounted, as did pressure for a stronger policy vis-à-vis Cuba. The Republicans announced that Cuba would be the dominant issue in the November congressional elections; Senators Kenneth Keating and Barry Goldwater—the

had made a dangerous miscalculation and that the only way to get the missiles out of Cuba without war or major appeasement was to impress Khrushchev, as never before, with his determination. The blockade option appealed to Kennedy because it offered him a badly needed opportunity to correct Khrushchev's misjudgment by means short of more dangerous, irreversible military actions such as the air strike option. The blockade, therefore, served a tactical objective that was essentially psychological.

latter a possible presidential contender in 1964—were hitting especially forcefully.

Under these circumstances, the Kennedy Administration felt obliged to mobilize itself to reassure the voters that the danger was being exaggerated, that the government knew exactly what was and was not going on in Cuba, and that more aggressive measures would not be justified. In strong statements on September 4, and again on September 13, Kennedy declared that there was no Soviet buildup of offensive weapons on the island, and that should there be in the future, “the gravest issues would arise.” Teeth were added to this statement by a presidential request to Congress on September 7 for standby authority to call up 150,000 reserves.

Kennedy’s statements were issued more out of a desire to calm the American public than to warn the leaders of the Soviet Union.²² What gave them a certain ambiguity for deterrence dynamics was that this was known in the Kremlin. It seems likely that the Soviet leaders heavily discounted the President’s declarations, perhaps virtually to the point of ignoring them, precisely because they were so obviously motivated by internal political needs.

If it is true that Khrushchev and his comrades discounted Kennedy’s warnings because they were “only political,” this perception involved a dual error in their understanding of the American political system. In the first place, the President had not only pledged himself to act if missiles were introduced, but had consistently deemphasized this danger as unreal. Once the missiles were discovered, therefore, he would have a stronger, not a weaker, motivation to do something about them than he would if he had not made or accepted this issue as a “political”

²² These statements were regarded within the administration as a rather inexpensive form of insurance that should eliminate any possible Soviet miscalculation, although it was assumed that any Soviet offensive activity in Cuba was extremely unlikely. Roger Hilsman, a member of the administration at the time, explicitly asserts that Kennedy’s public statements were primarily motivated by his desire to deal with his domestic critics. Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, pp. 196–97.

one. As one writer puts it, when the missiles were indeed discovered in October, "the United States might not be in mortal danger but the Administration most certainly was."²³

In fact, President Kennedy's motivation in issuing the statements was complex and multidimensional, and it is this second aspect especially that one doubts was fully comprehended in the Kremlin. The Cuban missile crisis when it sprang forth engaged both the personal and political prestige of the President and the interests and national prestige of the United States. Some of Kennedy's critics have fastened on the President's personal and political motives and, deploring them, have argued that American interests were not sufficiently at stake to justify Kennedy's taking the United States and the world to the brink of thermonuclear war. We believe this interpretation exaggerates the role of Kennedy's personal and narrow political motivation at the expense of what he felt was at stake in terms of broader national interests. Certainly both aspects of his motivation were important, and it is impossible to separate the two. Whether we like it or not, a leader's sense of his personal and political stakes usually enters in some way into his judgment of his country's interests. Moreover, there is often some basis in fact to encourage a leader's tendency to identify his personal stakes in an issue with those of party and country. We must remember that nations are not disembodied entities; on many important matters, they deal with each other only through the actions, mentalities, and emotions of the persons who lead them. Moreover, domestic politics can seldom be neatly separated from the conduct of foreign policy. The leaders of each nation must take this into account when they deal with each other.²⁴

This was particularly true in the Cuban missile crisis. In fact, it is only a slight exaggeration to say that Khrushchev could hardly have thought of a better way to insure that all aspects of

²³ *Ibid.*, pp. 196–98.

²⁴ Allison stresses these themes, and provides a persuasive account of the complexity and inseparability of the stakes from Kennedy's standpoint. *Essence of Division*, pp. 193–95.

Kennedy's motivation would be strongly aroused and so fused together as to become virtually inseparable. In the situation that Khrushchev had created, however hard the President might have tried, he could not have found a way to accept damage to his personal political stakes without also accepting damage to major U.S. interests.

The fact that the secret Soviet deployment of missiles would inflict personal and political humiliation on the President could not have escaped Khrushchev's attention when he *planned* the operation as well as while he was carrying it out. Of the several aspects of his bold gambit that show poor judgment on his part, his willingness to inflict such humiliation upon Kennedy is certainly among the most irresponsible.

This said, it also cannot be denied that the President's strong efforts early in September to reinforce the previously quite generalized deterrence of any offensive use of Cuba were quite inadequate for the purpose they were actually required to serve. Unknown to Kennedy, the deployment of offensive missiles had not merely been decided upon but was well along in implementation. The first missiles were already leaving their Soviet ports when Kennedy made his first statement.²⁵ At this late stage, it would have been very difficult for Khrushchev to reverse himself, even in the absence of complicating factors. The deployment operation was a complex one and had acquired its own momentum.

And there were complicating factors. If the available indications are correct that Khrushchev's original decision had en-

²⁵ It is true, as Allison observes (*Ibid.*, pp. 232–34), that before Soviet missiles actually reached Cuba on September 8, top-level officials (Sorensen and Robert Kennedy) did have an opportunity to indicate the administration's attitude in private conversations with Soviet Ambassador Dobrynin. Also, of course, the President's September 4 statement had been issued and, the previous day, his request for authority to call up reserves sent to Congress. The second, stronger, presidential statement followed before the deployment actually began on Cuban soil between September 15 and 20. But the purpose of Dobrynin's conversations apparently was merely to add to the deception in which the USSR was engaging. On both occasions Dobrynin, on instruction from Khrushchev, gave explicit assurance that no ground-to-ground missiles or other major offensive weapons were being brought into Cuba.

countered some opposition within the Soviet government,²⁶ then it would have been all the more difficult for Khrushchev to pull back now. To do so would have required him to tacitly concede the correctness of arguments others had made that a missile deployment would be too risky. It would also lay him open to charges from other Soviet leaders that he had retreated prematurely and perhaps unnecessarily, thereby depriving the Soviet Union of a chance for a major success. While classical Bolshevik doctrine enjoins good Bolsheviks to retreat when faced with danger, in practice this injunction has necessarily been incorporated into the Soviet approach to risk-acceptance already described, which appears to lie at the root of the Soviet government's unwillingness to call off its missile deployment on the basis of the two warnings Kennedy issued in early September.

Kennedy attempted to reinforce deterrence in Cuba without having before him a reasoned analysis, or working hypothesis, as to how the Soviet leaders might conceivably have persuaded themselves that the deployment of missiles was a calculable, controllable risk. Nor was it generally appreciated at this time in American decision-making circles that the Kremlin might find very significant risks calculable and controllable so long as they were expected to arise later rather than earlier in a crisis. The fact that the Kennedy Administration thought a Cuban missile deployment would be a high-risk, unacceptable option for the Soviets did not necessarily mean that the Soviets thought so.

The available record does not suggest that any attempt was made by the administration to construct a hypothetical Soviet risk calculus, however implausible initially, by which a Cuban deployment might seem reasonable given the *Soviet* attitude on high-but-deferred risks. Indeed, when the administration decided to draw the line on what it would tolerate in Cuba, there is no indication that either the President or his advisers thought

²⁶ Allison's discussion (*Essence of Decision*, pp. 112–13; 133–34; 234) of possible internal opposition to Khrushchev's decision draws upon Kolkowicz, "Conflicts in Soviet Party-Military Relations" and Michael Tatu, *Power in the Kremlin*.

the task sufficiently difficult, complicated, or interesting to warrant making any special effort to obtain the knowledge and judgment of American Sovietologists. Rather, the available record suggests that the task of designing means for reinforcing the deterrence of any dangerous Soviet moves in Cuba was handled through routine procedures.²⁷ At a minimum, it seems very safe to say that far less was done to assure high-quality policy planning to prevent deterrence from failing than was done to attempt to rescue the situation *after* it had failed. The fact that this is, in a sense, eminently understandable should not be allowed to obscure the point that prevention of deterrence failure is in actuality at least as important as coping with deterrence failure.

The American government's failure to reinforce deterrence adequately in September 1962 is the more striking because a properly designed effort might well have succeeded. What is known of Soviet behavior strongly suggests that Khrushchev's earlier calculations leading to the deployment would have included some kind of recognition of the possibility that it might have to be called off before it was completed—and even might well have included true contingency plans for such an event. Furthermore, the very existence of elements with the Soviet hierarchy who were skeptical of the value of the plan, or thought it too risky, might, depending upon their location in the communications flow, have meant great receptivity in the Kremlin to a properly designed deterrent signal.²⁸

²⁷ Little information is available on this aspect of policy formation. Schlesinger reports that on September 4 "The Secretary of State brought over a draft of the warning. The President showed it to the Attorney General [Robert Kennedy], who recommended stiffening it with an explicit statement that we would not tolerate the import of offensive weapons." *A Thousand Days*, p. 798. Sorensen reports merely that a series of meetings were held at the White House preceding the President's decision to repeat his warning on September 13. *Kennedy*, p. 671.

²⁸ A public statement suggesting a rapid U.S. *military* response to any Cuban missile deployment might or might not have been difficult for the Kennedy Administration to make. But it is difficult to see why the administration could not have communicated privately to the Kremlin that—*because* of the heavy pressure from the Republicans and other "hawk" elements—the U.S. government

In the event, of course, the administration's actual efforts to reinforce deterrence had no effect, except possibly to accelerate the already rapid schedule for bringing the MRBMs to operational status. We have already suggested two reasons for this: the Soviets' scepticism about Kennedy's character and personal strength and their tendency to discount his public warnings as politically motivated. It seems likely that as September faded into October a third reason joined in reassuring the Kremlin. The continuing public statements out of Washington that nothing untoward was occurring in Cuba may have nourished Soviet hopes that their deployment would actually go undiscovered until the MRBMs were ready. Or, as time continued to pass and Soviet leaders assumed that Kennedy must have at least formed some suspicions and anxieties as to what they were doing, they may have thought that the President did not wish to make a public issue of it until after the 1962 elections.²⁹

The Defender's Response to Warning: The Intelligence Response

Clearly, the Soviet gamble depended heavily for its success upon the United States' remaining blind to the fact that its deterrence policy for Cuba was being challenged until the missiles were operational and could exercise their own counterdeterrence—or at least until they were close enough to being operational so that they could be made fully ready while Washington was trying to fashion its response. The Cuban mis-

would be obliged to react immediately and decisively to such a contingency. This rather cheap signal would have played to the true vulnerability in the Soviet risk calculus—the fear that risks might be immediate and not remote after all.

²⁹ Hilsman offers the interpretation that Gromyko might well have concluded from Kennedy's failure to raise the issue of the missile deployment explicitly in their meeting on October 18 that the President did not intend to do anything really drastic, at least until after the elections; and so the Russian leaders were lulled into a false sense of security. *To Move A Nation*, p. 199; also pp. 166–67.

sile crisis is therefore quite distinctive in that the challenge to deterrence took the form of a force deployment rather than a military attack or other directly offensive action. This distinctive feature of the crisis put a premium on the defending power's intelligence apparatus—which, however, was called upon for once to discover merely the opponent's capabilities and not his intentions.

Those who have examined the question generally agree that the discovery of the Soviet missiles and the way in which this was accomplished must be considered a distinct success for U.S. intelligence. At the same time, they maintain that U.S. intelligence could and should have become suspicious of Soviet activities sooner than it did. The discovery of the missiles on October 14 came none too soon. The initial batch of MRBMs was nearing readiness; had these missiles become operational before or very shortly after they were discovered, President Kennedy would have been faced with just the difficult problem the Soviets were hoping to impose on him. In this crisis the *timing* of the intelligence discovery of the opponent's challenge to deterrence played a pivotal role, so that it is worth examining in some detail the roots of what must be classified as a near-failure of American intelligence. We have identified five factors that, when woven together and interacting, came fairly close to generating a U.S. intelligence and foreign policy failure of the first magnitude.

THE SPECIAL ROLE OF THE U-2 AIRCRAFT

Both before the missiles were discovered and afterwards, critics of the administration's response to the Soviet military buildup in Cuba dwelt on the failure of U.S. intelligence appraisers to pay more heed to refugee and agent reports—one in particular had called attention to a truck convoy in Cuba that included exceptionally long trailers. In doing so, however, the critics failed to take into account the special role of U-2 overflights of Cuba in the administration's overall intelligence ef-

fort. As published accounts make clear, if and when reports from agents and refugees raised bothersome questions about activity in Cuba, intelligence officials then established a requirement for U-2 photographic coverage of the areas in which suspicious activity had been reported. Understandably, the fact that U-2 pictures were capable of providing relatively firm evidence on many possible military activities in Cuba made intelligence appraisers less dependent upon agents' and refugees' reports, and less inclined to rely upon them for conclusions regarding Soviet activities and intentions.

There are, of course, some risks in becoming overly dependent upon a single, generally superior source of intelligence information. An interesting and important aspect of this case concerns the fact that some of the latent risks of relying so heavily upon U-2 flights did materialize and led to a near-failure of intelligence. This part of the story was obscured in early disclosures and in testimony before congressional committees that held hearings in 1963 on various aspects of the missile crisis. In several early efforts to explain the sluggishness with which intelligence appraisers responded to available clues of the missile deployment, the peculiar role which overreliance on the U-2 had played was not recognized or given proper weight.³⁰

But how could so excellent an intelligence source have been misused or have led the intelligence effort astray? The answer to this question lies in the impact which the faulty U.S. assessment of Soviet strategic intentions had on the U-2 effort. Until late August, two U-2 flights routinely covered Cuba each month.³¹ If the weather permitted, each flight covered the whole island in a single trip. Following the discovery of the first SAM installations by the U-2 flight of August 29, the sched-

³⁰ Even before the crisis ended, suspicion had arisen that the U-2 flights over Cuba had not been scheduled in an optimal manner. See the bibliography to this chapter for a detailed discussion of the "photography gap" and its treatment in various sources.

³¹ The following paragraphs draw primarily upon the accounts by Elie Abel and Roger Hilsman.

ule of overflights was stepped up. Between August 29 and October 7, six U-2 flights took place (September 5, 17, 26, and 29 and October 5 and 7) without discovering anything beyond SAM sites, MIG fighter planes on various Cuban airfields, and Komar torpedo boats armed with short-range rockets. But the disturbing fact is that all these flights except the one on September 5 *limited their photographic sweeps to that portion of Cuba lying east of Havana*. In the meantime, the medium-range missiles were being emplaced in *western* Cuba. They were to be discovered there by the U-2 flight of October 14.

The question arises, then, why U-2s did not overfly western Cuba during this critical period of well over a month. The answer lies in the fact that a high-level policy decision was taken on September 10 to alter the flight pattern of the U-2s in order to minimize the risk that one of these planes might be shot down over Cuba.³² On the preceding day (September 9) a U-2 belonging to the Chinese Nationalists had been destroyed in the air over the Chinese mainland. Mindful of the U-2 incident of 1960, high-level officials in the administration feared that an incident of this kind in the tense Cuban situation might raise a political storm in the U.N. and throughout the world that might deny the United States further use of the U-2s over Cuba. Accordingly, they preferred to impose constraints on the flight paths taken by the U-2s rather than accept the risk that such flights might be cancelled altogether.

Ironically, the new policy of caution with regard to U-2 flights applied particularly to overflights of western Cuba. It was there that the Soviet deployment of SAMs had proceeded

³² This decision resulted from a meeting on that day in McGeorge Bundy's office of the Committee on Overhead Reconnaissance (COMOR). Secretary of State Rusk, a member of the committee, is reported to have taken the lead in recommending that the usual flight patterns be modified to minimize the risk of a shoot-down. Instead of covering the whole island in a single flight, the alternative plan was adopted of scheduling shorter, more frequent flights that "dipped into" Cuban air space, and also a larger number of "peripheral" flights that would peer into Cuba from beyond the three-mile limit. Abel, *Missile Crisis*, p. 14; Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, pp. 174, 190.

with “astonishing speed” and, hence, where the danger of a U-2 being shot down was the greatest.³³

But it was also there that the need for U-2 photographic coverage was the greatest. The “astonishing speed” of the SAM deployment, after all, signaled that something needed to be heavily protected. There is even some reason to believe that U.S. intelligence officials considered the San Cristobal–Guanajay area of western Cuba to be the logical place for offensive missiles, if the Soviets had decided to deploy them.³⁴ But evidently, their disbelief that the Soviets would do so was strong enough to resolve the issue in favor of exercising greater caution with U-2 flights, so as not to risk a major incident.

There is, incidentally, no indication of any disagreement among the top officials who made the decision to curtail U-2 flight coverage of Cuba. Evidently they readily agreed that the proper course should be one of caution. It should be noted, however, that CIA Director John McCone, who had earlier advanced the thesis that SAMs were being deployed to cover and protect introduction of strategic missiles, was on a prolonged vacation outside the country when the decision was made. It is possible that McCone did not learn of the decision of September 10 until he returned in early October.³⁵

³³ Abel (*Missile Crisis*, p. 14), more clearly than Hilsman, makes the point that the SAM deployment was known to have taken place with great speed, particularly west of Havana, and he implies that this dictated particular caution in authorizing overflights of western Cuba.

³⁴ Hilsman (*To Move a Nation*, pp. 175–76) refers to a CIA intelligence appraisal which held that the SAM deployment was “the most advanced” in the San Cristobal and Guanajay areas. He adds that in a special intelligence meeting of October 4 to discuss the resumption of U-2 overflights of western Cuba, “No mention was made . . . of the possibility of missiles in the area, but it was perfectly obvious that if missiles had been deployed in Cuba they would have to be in this region.” *Ibid.*

³⁵ Abel’s account implies that McCone did not: “McCone returned from his wedding trip to discover that western Cuba had not been overflown for a month. He promptly suggested, at a special conference on October 4, that the whole island be photographed at once with special attention to its western end.” Abel, *Missile Crisis*, p. 15. It should be noted, however, that in other matters McCone was kept informed of developments in Washington during his absence.

If the caution displayed by high-level officials in curtailing the U-2 flights seemed reasonable at the time, nonetheless the incident strongly emphasizes the critical role played by the *belief* that the Soviets would not deploy offensive missiles. Given this belief, it seemed clearly justified to responsible top-level officials of the government to accept a partial degradation of the primary intelligence capability available to the United States for discovering and verifying Soviet intentions. It is also reasonable to conclude, as Hilsman does, that “there might have been a greater sense of urgency [to continue full coverage of Cuba by U-2s] if the overall judgment had been that the Soviets probably would put missiles into Cuba rather than that they probably would not.”³⁶

THE MISCALCULATION OF SOVIET INTENTIONS

This leads us to search for the more fundamental factors and assumptions that lay at the root of the Kennedy Administration’s belief that the Soviets would not go so far as to deploy offensive missiles. To this end, we shall now attempt to dissect the “anatomy of miscalculation” on the American side, and to show that it grew out of an inability to envisage how the Soviet leaders were calculating the risks of a missile deployment.

In late August, photographic intelligence had established that surface-to-air antiaircraft missiles were being installed in Cuba. This had reinforced speculation and rumors that the Soviet arms buildup might proceed along dangerous lines, that the Russians might be converting Cuba into a Soviet base, and that they might be tempted to install longer-range missiles in Cuba.

³⁶ Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 190. After a detailed assessment of the unfolding intelligence picture Hilsman concludes that had U-2s been used fully, “The soonest that the construction could have been recognized as missile sites was probably some time after September 15. . . .” Similarly, Sorensen reports the view of intelligence specialists that the missiles might have been discovered three weeks earlier than they were had photo-reconnaissance flights been made over western Cuba in late September, Sorensen, *Kennedy*, p. 675.

It was in this context that the United States Intelligence Board met on September 19 to consider the question of Soviet intentions in the light of the evidence available on the continuing arms shipments to Cuba. The board considered and approved a national intelligence estimate (NIE) on this subject. As reported by Elie Abel and Roger Hilsman, this NIE concluded, in effect, that the Soviets would not undertake a deployment of offensive missiles into Cuba.³⁷ An examination of available accounts of this NIE enables us to infer that the error in this intelligence appraisal rested not in underestimation of Soviet motivation but rather in an inability to understand how Soviet leaders would assess the risks of a missile deployment.

The NIE recognized that the Soviets might be tempted to put missiles into Cuba for several reasons: in Elie Abel's account, "chiefly for the psychological effect of such a move throughout Latin America" and because "Khrushchev might wish in this way to strengthen his position in preparation for some new move against Berlin."³⁸ Hilsman's account of the NIE mentions neither of these two considerations but adds another: "The estimate hedged, however, by noting that medium or intermediate range missiles in Cuba would significantly increase the Soviet capacity to strike at America's heartland and go far toward altering the strategic balance of power between East and West. It therefore urged the intelligence community to maintain a continuous alert."³⁹

It is evident, therefore, that U.S. analysts did indeed foresee at least some of the substantial advantages that might tempt Soviet leaders to undertake the missile deployment. Where they erred was in assuming that the Soviet leaders would regard a missile deployment as a high-risk strategy, whereas with the benefit of hindsight it appears that the Soviets perceived it as a

³⁷ The two accounts coincide in their description of the conclusion the NIE came to and the general reasoning on which it was based; there is, however, some difference (though not necessarily contradiction) between them as regards the particulars of the NIE's reasoning. See Abel, *Missile Crisis*, p. 12, and Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 172.

³⁸ Abel, *The Missile Crisis*, p. 23.

³⁹ Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 172.

low-risk option. The U.S. estimators erred particularly in failing to envisage—by failing to ask?—how the Soviets might satisfy themselves that the missile deployment was a *calculable and controllable risk*.

Thus, the NIE of September 19 reasoned that the Soviets would decide against a missile deployment because they “realized the Americans would be likely to discover the missiles and would probably react strongly—that, in other words, the likelihood of exposure was high and the probable consequences bad.”⁴⁰ (This was the critical point of error in the judgment of Soviet intentions; we shall return to it shortly.) The NIE’s judgment that Soviet leaders would forego the temptation of a missile deployment was buttressed by additional considerations. In Hilsman’s words,

when it came to nuclear matters . . . the Soviets were cautious. Never, for example, had they positioned strategic nuclear weapons outside the Soviet Union—even in Eastern Europe, where they would have been less provocative and much easier to defend than they would be in Cuba. Both air and sea communications between Cuba and the Soviet Union were long, hazardous, and peculiarly vulnerable to American interdiction. Castro was a self-elected member of the bloc—which runs counter to Soviet conceptions of themselves and their world—and the regime and Castro himself were unstable, hardly to be trusted either as the recipients of really dangerous weapons or as the hosts for weapons that remained under Soviet control.⁴¹

On the face of it, the weight of these considerations seemed compelling to U.S. intelligence estimators; it drove them to conclude that Khrushchev would not deploy offensive missiles into Cuba. This was, clearly, the single best guess as to Soviet intentions, particularly in the absence of concrete intelligence, like the U-2 might furnish, to the contrary. And, as Elie Abel and Roger Hilsman indicate, few if any specialists on Soviet behavior inside or outside the government were disposed to regard it as plausible that the Soviets would take the action they did.

⁴⁰ *Ibid.* Hilsman’s account is consonant with Elie Abel’s in this respect.

⁴¹ *Ibid.*

Hindsight in this case supports the familiar caveat that in matters of this kind it is never sufficient to define the task of estimating intentions in terms of a "single best guess." This particular danger is widely recognized by analysts and is usually avoided by them. Alternative hypotheses as to the opponent's intentions are usually considered, and an effort is made to assign relative probabilities to them. The source of the error—in this case and elsewhere—was, rather, more subtle and more dangerous. It consists of the tendency to judge the relative probabilities of the alternatives prematurely, before all hypotheses, *including the seemingly unlikely ones*, have been subjected to the detailed analysis required to convert them into "conditional predictions."

In estimating an opponent's intentions, to avoid surprise one must ask whether there could possibly be something present in the situation at hand that might lead the opponent to act contrary to the way one regards as probable. The need for such an inquiry would be obvious enough even if it had not been demonstrated repeatedly in past cases of miscalculation that resulted in surprise. The real question, therefore, is how best to make this inquiry. The "conditional prediction" method attempts to construct a line of reasoning, however implausible initially, by which the opponent might find a seemingly undesirable option attractive and reasonable. By actually synthesizing a hypothetical set of circumstances under which the opponent might select the apparently implausible option, an analyst may suddenly discover that the opponent's "preconditions" for activating that option are closer to being realized in the situation at hand than he had thought.

If the method of conditional predictions had been employed in the Cuban case, some U.S. analysts would have been charged with formulating a detailed working hypothesis regarding Soviet risk calculations according to which the missile deployment *would* emerge as a feasible option in Soviet eyes. There is, however, no indication that anyone did present a reasoned, systematic case for the proposition that Soviet leaders might judge a missile deployment to be a calculable, control-

lable risk worth accepting in return for the great advantages it promised to bestow. We shall return to this aspect of the U.S. estimate when we consider the role of CIA Director John McCone, who attempted to play the devil's advocate.⁴²

We have already noted the major assumptions which led the Soviet leadership to regard the missile venture as an initiative bearing acceptable risks: the plausible hope that the MRBM rapid-deployment capability would permit a *fait accompli*; the expectation that Kennedy's declarations regarding offensive weapons in Cuba were politically motivated and would not be seriously executed once the weapons were in place; the expectation that the cumbersome American political machinery would react sluggishly to any premature discovery of the missiles, and that Kennedy personally would be incapable of a firm and prompt response; and so on. None of these Soviet assumptions seem to have been considered in the U.S. assessment of the Kremlin's plausible options. Thus, we may say that Washington miscalculated by failing to consider how Moscow might miscalculate the risks of a missile deployment to conclude that they were acceptable. If this interpretation is correct, it strengthens the generalization that wars and dangerous crises often grow out of interacting miscalculations on both sides.

THE IMPORTANCE OF THE POLICY BACKGROUND

Still to be considered is the question whether, as in the Korean War case, the dominant U.S. foreign policy attitude prevalent at that time exercised a subtle, yet perhaps potent influence in reducing the receptivity of U.S. policy-makers and intelligence analysts to the available warning of the opponent's intentions. Two distinctly different interpretations of the impact of the dominant policy attitude have been offered that are on the face of it sharply contradictory. On the one hand, Roberta Wohlstetter suggests that there was a distinct lack of receptivity to early

⁴² See also the discussion in chapter 20 of miscalculations which lead to intelligence failures.

clues of a missile deployment, induced in part by the high priority the White House gave to relaxation of tensions with the Soviet Union. According to this thesis, knowledge of Kennedy's policy goal subtly discouraged intelligence specialists from giving more weight to discrepant information coming in that suggested a possible Soviet missile deployment. Though Mrs. Wohlstetter does not employ the language of psychological theory on behalf of her interpretation, it is nonetheless quite consistent with cognitive dissonance theory.⁴³ Her study of Pearl Harbor and other cases leads her to emphasize the pervasive influence of the dominant policy background on intelligence evaluation:

When an official policy or hypothesis is laid down, it tends to obscure alternative hypotheses, and to lead to overemphasis of the data that support it, particularly in a situation of increasing tension, when it is important not to "rock the boat."⁴⁴

This is an important generalization, and Mrs. Wohlstetter's explanation is indeed plausible. But in the absence of more direct evidence than she is able to provide, it is not compelling.⁴⁵ Roger Hilsman has examined her hypothesis and rejected it, arguing at some length that "the intelligence community had been concerned about the possibility that the Soviets might put missiles in Cuba from the beginning of the arms build-up."⁴⁶ He indicates that many of the early reports of Soviet activity that have been alluded to as clues

⁴³ See Festinger, *Theory of Cognitive Dissonance*.

⁴⁴ R. Wohlstetter, "Cuba and Pearl Harbor," pp. 699, 701. A similar thesis is reflected in Allison's *Essence of Decision*.

⁴⁵ Mrs. Wohlstetter's point, however, is part of a more comprehensive interpretation advanced in her article. Some other factors she mentions appear to be more important than the general policy background in accounting for Washington's sluggishness and lack of receptivity to the possibility of a missile deployment. The other factors include: (1) technological and/or logistical surprise; (2) inevitable physical delays in transmission and checking of intelligence reports; (3) the "cry-wolf" phenomenon; (4) the human tendency, in which policy-makers and intelligence specialists share, to see what one wants or expects to see; (5) an incorrect general expectation as to the opponent's behavior patterns.

⁴⁶ Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 175.

whose significance was overlooked at the time were not yet available to the estimators when the NIE of September 19 was formulated. Far from discouraging sensitivity to new clues, Hilsman argues, the NIE “did warn that the military advantages of a successful deployment of missiles to Cuba would be so great that the intelligence operators should be particularly alert.”⁴⁷

An entirely different picture of the nature and impact of the U.S. policy background just before the Cuban crisis erupted has been advanced by revisionist historian David Horowitz. According to Horowitz, Kennedy was seeking a showdown with the Soviets (and not, as Wohlstetter has it, a relaxation of tensions). If the Horowitz thesis is correct, this policy background should have made administration officials not unreceptive to warning, as the Wohlstetter interpretation implies, but particularly alert to any clues of a missile deployment. In developing his thesis, Horowitz drew upon several articles by Cyrus Sulzberger in the *New York Times* (October 20, 22, 24, 1962; February 25, 1963). Horowitz argues that there was “an important dynamic element in the planning of U.S. policy.”⁴⁸ The administration’s strong action in the Cuban crisis was, for Horowitz, by no means merely a response to the military threat created by the missile deployment. Rather, he holds, citing Sulzberger, that some weeks before the Cuban confrontation, Washington had become convinced that the moment of truth over Berlin would arise later in the year and resolved to have a showdown with Russia at a time and place of its own choosing. Accordingly, Horowitz implies, when the Soviets were caught deploying missiles into Cuba, the Kennedy Administration deliberately overreacted, seizing upon it as “an opportune moment” to demonstrate its nuclear superiority and its willingness to risk war.⁴⁹

The Horowitz thesis, published in 1965, would encounter severe difficulties if it attempted to take account of detailed ma-

⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, pp. 187–89.

⁴⁸ Horowitz, *Free World Colossus*, p. 388.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, pp. 388–90.

materials published since then on the near failure of U.S. intelligence and American policy-making before and during the missile crisis. His thesis correctly grasps some aspects of Kennedy's rationale for *responding* to the missiles as he did; but it oversimplifies and distorts matters by reading history backwards to conclude that Kennedy must have been planning to escalate the Cold War and seized upon the missile deployment for this purpose. (The structure of Horowitz's interpretation is not an unfamiliar one in revisionist writings; we have seen that a similar interpretation has been offered for the outbreak of the Korean War and, for that matter, for Pearl Harbor.)

DOMESTIC AND BUREAUCRATIC POLITICS

Both the Wohlstetter and Horowitz theses can be criticized for oversimplifying the policy background and for dealing with, at best, only one strand of a more complex policy environment. There was in fact considerable diversity of view within the government at the time regarding what U.S. policy toward the Soviet Union should be, both in general and on specific issues. It is difficult to establish conclusively the influence of an unsettled policy background of this kind on the perception of the developing Soviet military buildup in Cuba. However, there is considerable evidence that disagreement over U.S. policy toward Cuba and toward the growing Soviet influence in Cuba did set into motion the play of "bureaucratic politics" within the administration, in ways that affected the use and interpretation of available intelligence on a possible Soviet deployment of missiles into Cuba.

Thus, it may be presumed that intelligence about the Soviet military buildup in Cuba, based on refugee and agent reports, was being leaked in one way or another to critics of the administration's policy.⁵⁰ The sources from which Senator Keating received the reports of a missile deployment which he used

⁵⁰ Allison, *Essence of Decision*, p. 192, asserts that some members of the military and intelligence community who disagreed with the administration's position leaked intelligence to congressmen and the press.

to criticize the administration have never been disclosed. Whether Senator Keating and other critics obtained their information through direct leaks from administration sources, or indirectly from some of the same intelligence sources which supplied the administration with some of its "raw" refugee and/or agent reports it is not possible to say.

We noted earlier that top-level officials in the administration were mobilized to counter the impact on public opinion of alarmist charges being made by Senator Keating and other critics. For this purpose, administration officials drew on their own classified intelligence estimates. As a result, intelligence specialists who were monitoring and appraising available information on Soviet activities in Cuba were forced to operate in a highly charged political atmosphere. But what effect this had on their estimates is not clear.

The situation was further complicated by the fact that John McCone, Director of the CIA, as early as the spring of 1962 had indicated a suspicion that the Russians might install medium-range missiles in Cuba. The first intimation that Soviet ground-to-air defense missiles were reaching Cuba hardened McCone's suspicion and, on August 22, he suggested to President Kennedy and McNamara that the SAMs were being emplaced in order to hide and protect the introduction of longer-range offensive missiles.⁵¹ What is not clear in available accounts of McCone's views is to what extent his suspicions achieved prescience and to what extent they were arrived at through hindsight, during the course of bureaucratic maneuvers that occurred after the event, to avoid or shift blame for the near failure of American intelligence. There may be some truth, in other words, to Roger Hilsman's contention that "no one knows how much doubt McCone really felt, for he often played the devil's advocate in arguing with his own estimators."⁵² Nonetheless,

⁵¹ According to Allison, "Kennedy heard this [McCone's interpretation of Soviet intentions] as what it was: the suspicion of a professional anti-Communist. McNamara seems to have feared that McCone's aggressiveness might push the Administration into unwarranted action." *Ibid.*, p. 150. On McCone's role, see also Krock, *Memoirs*, p. 378; and Weintal and Bartlett, *Facing the Brink*, p. 60.

⁵² Hilsman, *To Move a Nation*, p. 173.

there are important discrepancies between Hilsman's account and other accounts concerning the seriousness of McCone's suspicion and the extent to which he pushed it, against other members of the intelligence community, in an effort to alert top-level policy-makers.⁵³

One senses from available accounts of McCone's views and activities in this case a disturbing paradox: to the extent that the CIA director was playing devil's advocate, the very power and prestige of his position may have made it more difficult to secure an adequate assessment of his suspicions about Soviet intentions! The person filling the top-level intelligence position must indeed subject the judgments of estimators under him to independent, critical scrutiny before accepting them. Certainly he should also insure that alternative hypotheses—particularly unpopular ones—are adequately considered by well-qualified personnel. In this connection, he may have to encourage some of them to play the devil's advocate role, should it be necessary to do so in order to obtain a careful and sympathetic case for unpopular or low-probability hypotheses. But, it may be argued, so highly placed an intelligence official as the CIA Director should not attempt to play the devil's advocate role himself and to try to combine it with his other functions, with which it is likely to conflict. Rather, he should reserve his unique high-level position for evaluating the competing interpretations, including those produced by devil's advocates elsewhere within the organization.

⁵³ Hilsman reports (*Ibid.*, p. 173) that McCone was eventually persuaded by the more conservative (i.e., optimistic) interpretation advanced by intelligence appraisers in CIA who concluded that the Soviet Union would not go beyond deployment of air defense SAMs. But other sources (Abel, *Missile Crisis*, pp. 7–8, 12–13), evidently draw upon post-crisis interviews with McCone to report that the CIA Director waged a continuing struggle to have the NIE of September 19 reflect his greater concern about a possible missile deployment. From Cap Ferrat, where he was honeymooning, McCone is reported to have sent a series of telegrams to his deputy in CIA, General Marshal S. Carter, on September 7, 10, 13, 16, and 20. General Carter, however, did not distribute McCone's telegrams to the White House or elsewhere outside CIA. As Abel reports it, Carter did not do so because "He felt McCone had made plain his views before leaving Washington," and besides, McCone's hypothesis had been taken into account in preparing the NIE. *Missile Crisis*, pp. 12–13.

This point is reinforced by indications that McCone's effort to serve as devil's advocate did *not* produce an adequate treatment of the unpopular hypothesis that the Soviets might well be putting missiles into Cuba. The CIA Director must be credited with shrewd deductive reasoning in arguing his suspicions that air defense SAMs were being emplaced in Cuba primarily to hide and protect the later deployment of offensive missiles. But not being a specialist on Soviet behavior himself, he could not provide a plausible line of reasoning on the basis of which Soviet leaders might engage in such unusual behavior.

Moreover—a point to which we are inclined to give particular emphasis—McCone's personal espousal of a seemingly implausible hypothesis of Soviet intentions placed him in sharp competition with professional specialists on the Soviet Union. If a top-level intelligence official such as the CIA Director embraces a “wild” hypothesis and, because of his status in the government, is in a position to influence policy, it can indeed create special pressures on the professional specialists whom he outranks. In the present case, McCone's view of Soviet intentions—which in a sense he developed prematurely and in the absence of any evidence—may have served to mobilize Soviet specialists within the government on behalf of the conservative, more plausible view of Soviet intentions.⁵⁴

Given the grave impact McCone's hypothesis could have had on U.S. policy and given the acute and growing domestic political controversy surrounding the issue of Cuba, it must have seemed all the more important to the professional estimators to counter his views and to provide top policy-makers in the government with more responsible estimates of the opponent's intentions. If this interpretation is correct, it illustrates the adverse effects political controversy and bureaucratic politics can have on the performance of the intelligence function.

Available accounts give no indication that McCone or anyone else went beyond his shrewd deductive hypothesis concerning the possible relationship between SAMs and medium-

⁵⁴ Abel remarks, without clarifying his sources, that “within the intelligence community, some professionals smiled indulgently at McCone's seemingly fantastic conception.” *Missile Crisis*, pp. 7–8.

range missiles to construct a plausible account of how Soviet leaders might come to regard the risks of a missile deployment as calculable, controllable, and therefore acceptable. To develop this kind of plausible construction of Soviet risk calculations, McCone would have needed the help of specialists on Soviet behavior which, apparently, he did not have and may not have attempted to obtain. Rather, by personally undertaking advocacy of the unpopular hypothesis, the CIA Director may have inadvertently forced Soviet specialists within the administration to combine in rebutting him and may have pushed them into providing the “single best” guess of Soviet intentions rather than several well-reasoned alternative interpretations.

*U.S. MISUNDERSTANDING OF
THE SOVIET APPROACH
TO RISK CALCULATION*

We have already discussed the general failure of the high-level policy-makers in the Kennedy Administration to base their attempt to reinforce deterrence on an understanding of the peculiarly Soviet approach to risk calculation. Apparently, the same failure occurred at the level of intelligence assessment and analysis. Although in preceding years, U.S. intelligence agencies had gained a rather good general understanding of Soviet foreign policy behavior, either they had not yet penetrated the Soviet attitude on risks, or else they failed to apply their knowledge to the case at hand. Certainly, so far as can be told from the available record, the assessment of the evolving Cuban situation during September and early October did not include any awareness that the Soviets, while recognizing the fairly substantial *overall* risks implicit in a missile deployment, might regard the more dangerous hazards as likely to appear later in probable scenarios, after a sequence of intervening events that could be controlled. That such a view of the missile deployment option might reasonably be held in Moscow, and might lead to an acceptance of the option's risks, does not appear to be reflected in U.S. intelligence assessments at the time.

Understandably, Western analysts as well as decision-makers have tended to assume that Soviet risk acceptance was similar to their own. Failing to appreciate the distinctive Soviet understanding of the logic of hazard—in some ways more sophisticated than the usual Western approach—they have tended to blur the important time factor in risk acceptance; they have tended to be disturbed by risks of high magnitude, even though these risks may be some steps removed in time; they have been disposed to give less attention and weight to the controllability of risks through manipulation of intervening events. As a result, Western leaders and analysts both have been inclined to make distorted judgments regarding Soviet intentions, either exaggerating in their own minds the Soviet willingness to incur major risks (as, for instance, in some of the Berlin crises) or underestimating the willingness of the Soviets to undertake certain options (like the Cuban missile deployment) in the mistaken belief that the Soviets would regard them as too hazardous.⁵⁵

Distinguishing the approaches of different nations to risk acceptance is a kind of differentiation which has hardly been encouraged by traditional deterrence theory and practice, despite its importance—as the Cuban missile crisis shows.⁵⁶ Here again, we see American decision-makers willing to make a much more careful assessment of probable Soviet behavior in attempting to rescue the situation once deterrence has failed

⁵⁵ For a further development of these observations regarding the Soviet approach to calculation, see A. L. George, "The 'Operational Code': A Neglected Approach to the Study of Political Leaders and Decision-Making," *International Studies Quarterly*, 13, No. 2 (June 1969), 190–222.

⁵⁶ The general theory of deterrence assumes the same kind of rationality for all actors; it does not call attention to the important variation among actors who attempt to behave rationally in their approach to risk calculation and risk acceptance. Applications of deterrence strategy in real-life situations, however, must make this differentiation. The assumption that the opponent's approach to risk-calculation and risk-acceptance is the same as one's own will lead to possibly serious miscalculations of his intentions and to inadequate signaling of the credibility of one's commitment and resolution in reinforcement efforts. At the same time, however, to acquire reliable knowledge of an opponent's general orientation to risk-calculation and risk-acceptance, and to apply it effectively in the variety of situations that may arise, cannot be regarded as an easy task.

than in attempting to forestall its failure. In earlier crises, the Truman and Eisenhower Administrations had responded—as discussed in earlier case studies—with considerable caution to Soviet initiatives. Their cautious response was influenced by the peculiar image they held of Soviet leaders as being unpredictable and capable of impulsive behavior if “provoked” by American behavior in a crisis situation. In contrast, in the Cuban missile case Kennedy acted boldly in seizing the initiative and exerting severe pressure on Khrushchev. He did so on the basis of a quite different image of the opponent than that held by Truman and Eisenhower. As Robert Kennedy was to note, his brother’s image of Khrushchev played a decisive role in determining the choice of response to the discovery of the missiles. “The President believed from the start,” Robert Kennedy recalled, “that the Soviet Chairman was a rational, intelligent man who, if given sufficient time and shown determination, would alter his position.”⁵⁷ It is interesting that Kennedy maintained this image of Khrushchev, which was not universally held in the West by those who had viewed with dismay the Soviet Premier’s penchant for apparently uncontrollable outbursts.

Of a piece with Kennedy’s view of Khrushchev’s personality were his assumptions regarding the approach Soviet leaders take toward the management of international conflict. When at the outset of the crisis Kennedy and his advisers were considering what response to make to the missiles, the critical question they faced was whether Khrushchev could be induced to remove the missiles without direct application of force. Were the Soviet leaders committed irrevocably to the daring venture on which they had embarked? Had they already gone beyond the point of no return? Or were the Soviet leaders capable of “retreating,” as the classical Bolshevik doctrine had enjoined, when faced with overwhelming danger? Soviet experts in Washington supported the latter theory, and Kennedy, too, shared this premise regarding the Soviet “operational code.”

⁵⁷ Robert Kennedy, *Thirteen Days*, pp. 126–27.

He felt that Soviet leaders had miscalculated the risks of their action and that they were capable, at least in principle, of retreating. Such a premise, of course, bolstered the idea of a blockade coupled with a tightening of the screw and careful adherence to the requirements of crisis management. Were some other premise regarding Soviet behavior operative, it might well have favored an immediate air strike or, at the other extreme, an attempt at appeasement to buy Khrushchev's withdrawal of the missiles at a high price.

Aftermath: Deterrence since 1963

The Cuban missile crisis marked a turning point in the Cold War. The immediate consequences for Soviet-American relations were beneficial. As on earlier occasions in history when both sides in a tense crisis stepped back from the brink of war, a *détente* in U.S.-Soviet relations quickly followed. During the next ten months, Kennedy and Khrushchev cooperated to bring about the partial test-ban treaty. Policies that had dangerously exacerbated the earlier conflict were reexamined and modified. Contrary to all indications prior to the Cuban crisis, the Soviet government did not resume pressure on West Berlin; nor did Khrushchev's successors stir up this familiar battleground of the Cold War. Instead, negotiations pursued with patience and seriousness over a period of years finally resulted in 1972 in important agreements covering the status of West Berlin and the relationship between East and West Germany.

Perhaps of equal importance was the sobering effect the crisis had on Cold War uses of deterrence strategy and strategic power which, as we have emphasized, played an important role in the origins of the Cuban missile crisis. Thereafter, both sides substantially lowered their expectations regarding the extent to which deterrence and counter deterrence strategies could be used on behalf of foreign policy objectives. This was coupled, moreover, with a tacit mutual understanding that each side

would have to place greater reliance on other means of diplomacy for controlling and mediating their conflicting interests. We consider these developments in greater detail in the concluding chapter of this book. Here, we should note that the use of deterrence strategy as an instrument of American foreign policy indeed did not end after the partial *détente* of 1963. In a number of crisis or precrisis situations since then, the United States has attempted to apply deterrence on behalf of a weaker ally or neutral state. It would be beyond the scope of both the present study and the resources available to attempt to give detailed case history treatment to these more recent instances. They can only be briefly noted here.

The United States, of course, has attempted and continues to project a general deterrence “blanket” over the state of Israel. While the precise nature of this commitment and the lengths to which the United States would go to protect Israel’s survival have been left deliberately ambiguous, there is no doubt that a general effort to deter major attack on Israel has gone forward both in a consistent and oft-repeated declaratory policy and in action through the sale of advanced weapons, the exchange of intelligence information, etc. In addition, it has been reported that President Johnson delivered a specific deterrent threat to discourage Soviet intervention in the Six-Day War of 1967.

After the Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia in 1968, the United States, in conjunction with NATO, appeared to make a somewhat ambiguous deterrence effort on behalf of Rumania and Yugoslavia, which seemed to be threatened at that time by large Soviet troop concentrations.

Following the election of Allende as President of Chile in 1970, the United States evidently indicated that it would not intervene so long as Soviet military bases did not appear in Chile. It is not clear whether this was intended as a deterrence effort and, indeed, whether Washington took seriously the possibility that Soviet military bases might be established in that country.

A clearer instance of the resort to deterrence policy is provided by the Nixon Administration’s response to reports,

beginning in September 1970, that a submarine base to service Soviet missile-carrying submarines was being built in Cuba. The administration issued warnings that such a development would be viewed with the “utmost seriousness” as a violation of the 1962 agreement between Kennedy and Khrushchev for removal of the missiles from Cuba.

Deterrence efforts of various kinds have also been made in connection with the war in Southeast Asia. Prior to the U.S. escalation in 1965, the threat of American air attacks appears to have been intended to deter Hanoi from stepping up its assistance to the Viet Cong. Similarly, it seems probable that soon after coming to office in 1969, President Nixon conveyed a threat to resume air attacks against North Vietnam in order to deter any new large-scale North Vietnamese action in the South.

During the India-Pakistan War of 1971, the administration has asserted, it was concerned about and attempted to deter an Indian attack upon *West* Pakistan. To this end it employed declaratory policy, diplomatic gestures at the United Nations and elsewhere, and especially the signal of diverting the aircraft carrier *Enterprise* into the Indian Ocean.

In these cases and perhaps others the United States may have begun to experience a foretaste of what deterrence policies will need to adjust themselves to in the 1970s and possibly beyond, which we take up in the last chapter.

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Unusually detailed accounts of American policy-making leading to the confrontation over the missiles appear in publications by former members of the Kennedy Administration, particularly those by Hilsman, Schlesinger, and Sorensen. Elie Abel obtained important new material and details from interviews with members of the administration. Of the several congressional hearings that went into one or another aspect of the crisis, particularly valuable are the ones by Senator Stennis' Preparedness Investigating Subcommittee and the House DOD Appropriations Subcommittee. Chronologies and documents are provided by *The New York Times*' "Cuban Crisis: A Step-by-step Review," Larson, and (with valuable interpretations as well) Pachter.

Information on Soviet policy-making is, of course, much more limited. The full authenticity of the memoir *Khrushchev Remembers* remains uncertain. Available data and interpretations are provided by Horelick, Horelick and Rush, Kolkowicz, Tatu, Ulam, Allison, Lipson, and Linden.

A number of detailed scholarly studies of the missile crisis have been published. Particularly useful for our purposes are those by Horelick, Horelick and Rush, Young, Roberta Wohlstetter, and the joint article by the Wohlstetters. The Allison study is not only rich in insights and alternative hypotheses but covers available sources with unusual thoroughness. The study by George, Hall, and Simon focuses on Kennedy's use of coercive diplomacy and crisis management; it also contains material on Kennedy's complex motivation that has been incorporated into the present study.

The secret correspondence during the crisis between Kennedy and Khrushchev was declassified by the State Department in 1973. Through the courtesy of Professor Barton Bernstein, Stanford University, we were able to see it before this book went to press. The correspondence does not add significant new details to the public record.

Major sources for the discussion of Cold War uses of deterrence and strategic threats and of the “missile gap” problem are Horelick and Rush, Hilsman, Quester, and Licklider.

Analysis of the near-failure of American intelligence draws on a number of sources. Suspicion that the U-2 flights over Cuba had not been scheduled in an optimal manner had arisen even before the crisis was over; Kenworthy, *New York Times*, November 3, 1962. The Stennis Committee examined the possibility of a “photography gap” in U-2 coverage of Cuba in early 1963 and rejected the charges as “unfounded.” However, that report ignored altogether the critical question of the U-2 flight paths over Cuba between September 5 and October 24, noting merely that these flights “completed the coverage of those areas of Cuba which had been spotlighted as requiring early attention.” Congress, Senate, *Interim Report*, pp. 3, 8–9. Yet, the “photography gap” of some 38 days in U-2 coverage of *western* Cuba had already been officially confirmed in early February 1963 by Defense Secretary McNamara’s grudging admission of it during persistent cross examination by Congressmen Minshall and Ford. Congress, House, *Defense Appropriations*, esp. pp. 67–71 and 362–63, but also 25, 27–28, 45–6, 74. Writing in August 1963, Henry Pachter (*Collision Course*, p. 8) made no reference to a possible “photography gap” in U-2 coverage; but he offered indirect support for this thesis in vague hints by administration sources that in view of the emplacement of Soviet air defense missiles in Cuba, reconnaissance flights during September 1962 had been limited to “sideways approaches” and may not have utilized U-2 planes. In 1965 Sorensen (*Kennedy*, p. 672) remarked cryptically that U-2 incidents elsewhere in the world had led to a “high-level reexamination of that airplane’s use” over Cuba “and some delay in flights.”

These pieces were put together later in 1965 by Roberta Wohlstetter ("Cuba and Pearl Harbor"), who suggested that the administration's fear of losing a U-2 to Soviet air defense missiles may have led it to be cautious in scheduling U-2 flights over Cuba. But confirmation and adequate evaluation of this matter was not possible until additional disclosures concerning a change in policy governing U-2 flights were made by Elie Abel (*Missile Crisis*, 1966) and Roger Hilsman (*To Move a Nation*, 1967). Hilsman's earlier article on the Cuban crisis in 1964 had not disclosed the explanation for or consequences of the "photography gap." There was also no mention of this or, indeed, of the role of the U-2 in the intelligence effort in Knorr's article, "Failures in National Intelligence Estimates."

Allison's otherwise informative and incisive analysis fails to deal clearly with the effect of the photography gap on the near failure of U.S. intelligence in discovering the presence of missiles in Cuba. Instead, Allison gives misplaced emphasis in his explanation to the role of "the routines and procedures of the organizations that make up the U.S. intelligence community" and to the role of "overlapping bargaining games" among the suborganizations engaged in the intelligence effort. *Essence of Decision*, pp. 118–23, 187, 191–92. In his effort to emphasize the importance of two analytical models—the organizational process model and the bureaucratic politics model—of how foreign policy is made, Allison tends to impose these theories on the data, which distorts the explanation for the sluggishness and near failure of the U.S. intelligence effort. Thus, the high-level decision of September 10 to avoid direct overflights of western Cuba, which led to the photography gap, cannot be explained in terms of either the organizational process model or the bureaucratic politics model; it requires a different kind of explanation, which we attempt to provide in this chapter.

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Part Three



Toward a Reformulation of
Deterrence Theory